

***How to Assess and Evaluate
Family Functioning***

(David Olson's) Circumplex model of marital and family systems

- ▶ Professor, Department of Family Sciences, University of Minnesota, USA
- ▶ Key dimensions that are critical for understanding and treating marital and family systems
 - ▶ Cohesion/Connectedness/Togetherness
 - ▶ Flexibility (Adaptability)
- ▶ Used as a relational/family diagnosis based on research in marital and family dynamics



Cohesion

- ▶ The emotional bonding that members have with one another and the degree of individual autonomy that a person experiences in the family system
- ▶ “I” vs. “we”: Importance of maintaining one’s own individuality and intimacy as a unit/family.
- ▶ Variables that are used to assess family cohesion
 - ▶ Boundary
 - ▶ Independence, interdependence, or dependence
 - ▶ The degree of emotional bonding
 - ▶ E.g.) Do they enjoy a family-level activity together and yet each one has own hobbies that he/she enjoys?



		Disengaged	Separated	Connected	Enmeshed
Couple/Family Score		12	34	56	78
EMOTIONAL BONDING		Extreme emotional separateness. Lack of family loyalty.	Emotional separateness. Limited closeness. Occasional family loyalty.	Emotional closeness. Some separateness. Loyalty to family expected.	Extreme emotional closeness. Little separateness. Loyalty to family demanded.
FAMILY INVOLVEMENT		Very low involvement or interaction. Infrequent affective responsiveness.	Involvement acceptable. Personal distance preferred. Some affective responsiveness.	Involvement emphasized. Personal distance allowed. Affective interactions encouraged and preferred.	Very high involvement. Fusion, over-dependency. High affective responsiveness and control.
MARITAL RELATIONSHIP		High emotional separateness. Limited closeness.	Emotional separateness. Some closeness.	Emotional closeness. Some separateness.	Extreme closeness, fusion. Limited separateness.
PARENT-CHILD RELATIONSHIP		Rigid generational boundaries. Low p/o closeness.	Clear generational boundaries. Some p/o closeness.	Clear generational boundaries. High p/o closeness.	Lack of generational boundaries. Excessive p/o closeness.
INTERNAL BOUNDARIES		Separateness dominates.	More separateness than togetherness.	More togetherness than separateness.	Togetherness dominates.
TIME (Physical & Emotional)		Time apart maximized. Rarely time together.	Time alone important. Some time together.	Time together important. Time alone permitted.	Time together maximized. Little time alone permitted.
SPACE (Physical & Emotional)		Separate space needed and preferred.	Separate space preferred. Sharing of family space.	Sharing family space. Private space respected.	Little private space permitted.
DECISION-MAKING		Individual decision-making. (Oppositional)	Individual decision-making, but joint possible.	Joint decisions preferred.	Decisions subject to wishes of entire group.
EXTERNAL BOUNDARIES		Mainly focused outside the family.	More focused outside than inside family.	More focused inside than outside family.	Mainly focused inside the family.
FRIENDS		Individual friends seen alone.	Individual friendships seldom shared with family.	Individual friendships shared with family.	Family friends preferred. Limited individual friends.
INTERESTS		Disparate interests.	Separate interests.	Some joint interests.	Joint interests mandated.
ACTIVITIES		Mainly separate activities.	More separate than shared activities.	More shared than individual activities.	Separate activities seen as disloyal.
Global Cohesion Rating (1-8)		Very Low	Low to Moderate	Moderate to High	Very High

Flexibility (Adaptability)

- ▶ The ability of a marital/family system to change its power structure, roles, and relationship rules in response to situational and developmental stress
 - ▶ Range: from rigid to chaotic
- ▶ Variables that are used to assess family flexibility
 - ▶ Roles, Rules, Room for negotiation, Decision-making



		Rigid	Structured	Flexible	Chaotic
Couple/Family Score		1 2	3 4	5 6	7 8
LEADERSHIP (Control)		Authoritarian leadership. Parent(s) highly controlling.	Primarily authoritarian but some equalitarian leadership.	Equalitarian leadership with fluid changes.	Limited and/or erratic leadership. Parental control unsuccessful. Rebuffed.
DISCIPLINE (For families only)		Autocratic "law & order." Strict, rigid consequences. Not lenient.	Somewhat democratic. Predictable consequences. Seldom lenient.	Usually democratic. Negotiated consequences. Somewhat lenient.	Laissez-faire and ineffective. Inconsistent consequences. Very Lenient
NEGOTIATION		Limited negotiations. Decisions imposed by parents.	Structured negotiations. Decisions made by parents.	Flexible negotiations. Agreed upon decisions.	Endless negotiations. Impulsive decisions.
ROLES		Rigid generational boundaries. Low p/c closeness.	Clear generational boundaries. Some p/c closeness.	Clear generational boundaries. High p/c closeness.	Lack of generational boundaries. Excessive p/c closeness.
RULES		Unchanging rules. Rules strictly enforced.	Few rule changes. Rules firmly enforced.	Some rule changes. Rules flexibly enforced.	Frequent rule changes. Rules inconsistently enforced.
Global Flexibility Rating (1-8)		Very Low	Low to Moderate	Moderate to High	Very High



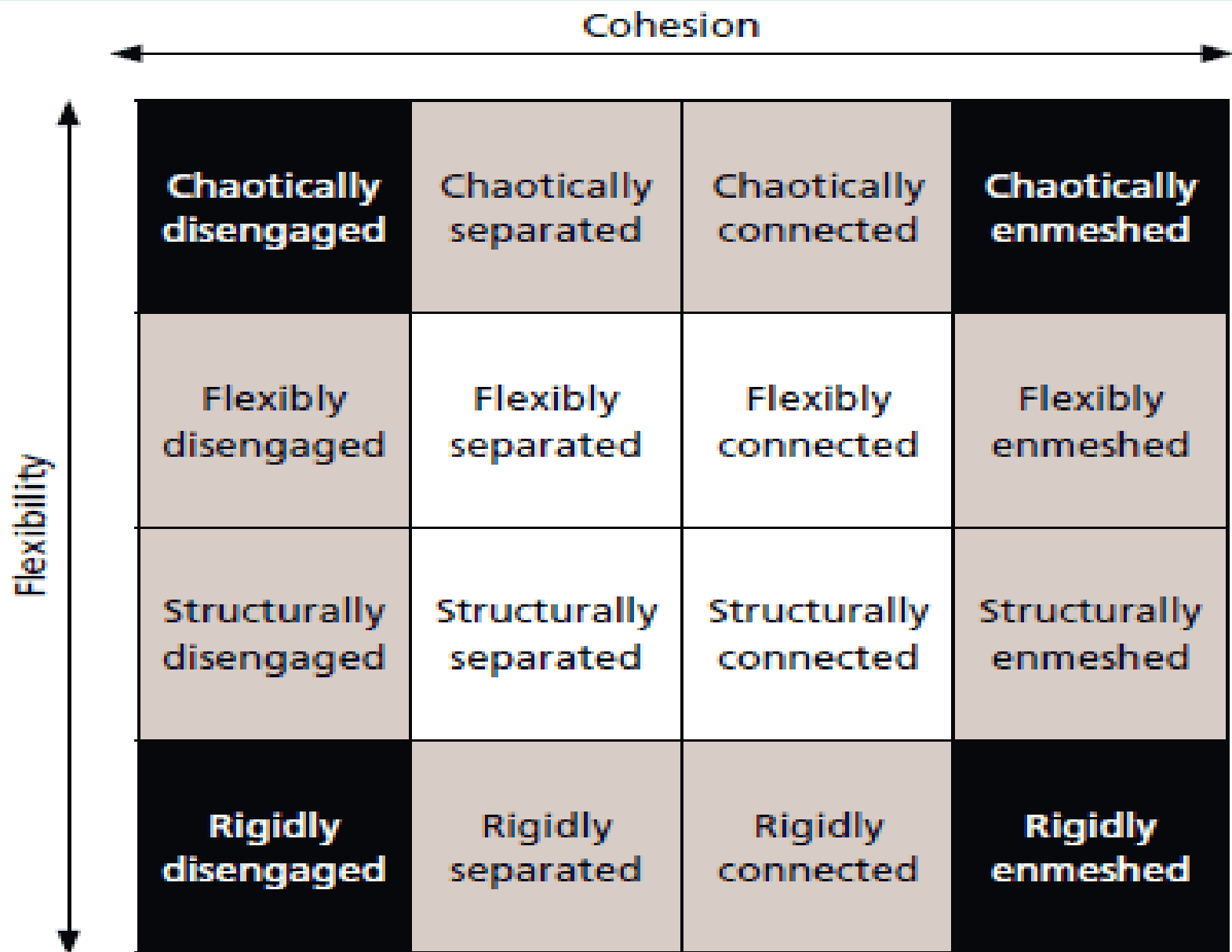


Figure 1. The Circumplex Model (after Olson, 2000)

Q1: What if spouses differ in their preferences regarding the balance on these dimensions?

- ▶ These levels can be altered by a couple to achieve a level that is acceptable to each individual.



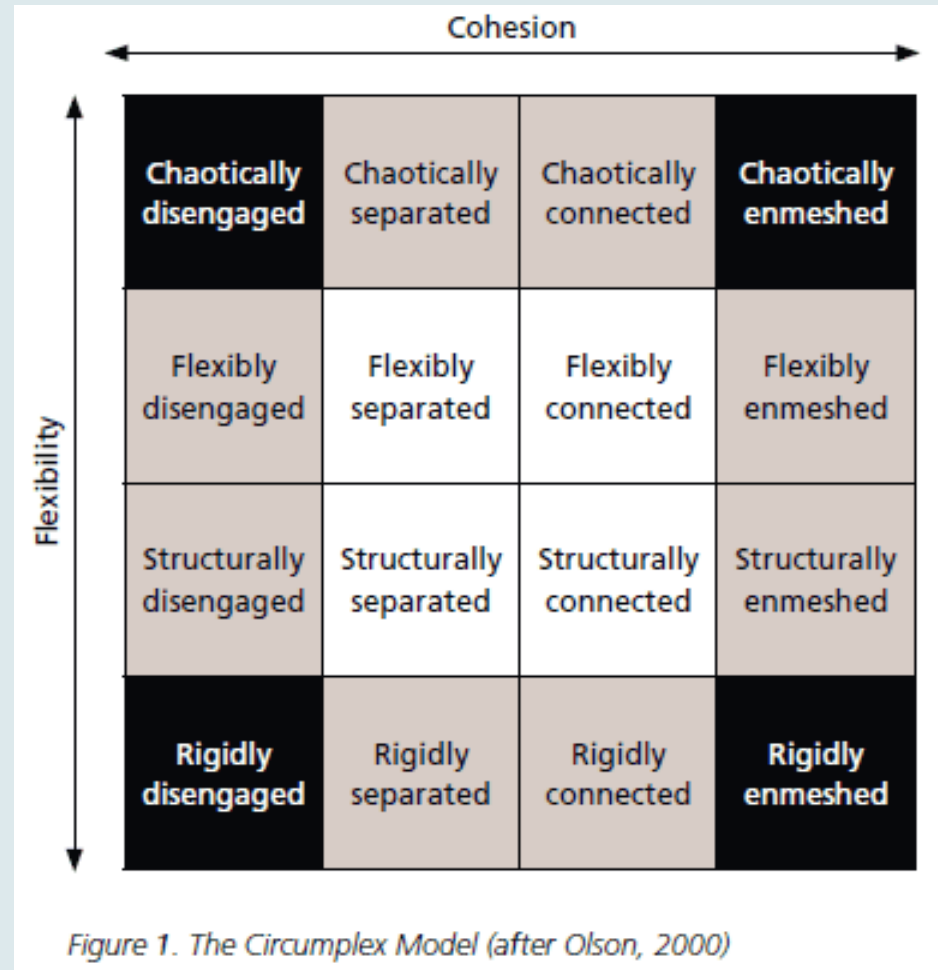
Cohesion

- ▶ Too much togetherness (e.g., people “in love”) can lead to relationship fusion or enmeshment.
- ▶ This may happen in all relationships, including couple, marital, and parent-child.
- ▶ In general, family researchers consider “balanced” couple/family to be more functional as opposed to disengaged or enmeshed couple/family.



Q2: Is chaotically enmeshed newly wed couple problematic?

- ▶ Being extreme on these dimensions can be acceptable during certain stages of the family life cycle
- ▶ **PROBLEMATIC** when families remain stuck at the extremes.



Q3: What might happen when a family experiences stress or crisis?

- ▶ A balanced family may become more extreme on flexibility (towards more chaotic system) and on cohesion (toward more enmeshed system)
- ▶ Once the stress has subsided, they usually return to a similar type of system prior to the stressful/crisis event [homeostasis]
- ▶ *Unbalanced* families lack the resources needed to change their family during stress, thus have more difficulty adapting to a crisis



Q3-1: What about a recently arrived immigrant family that is highly enmeshed during the first year in the host country?

- ▶ Being extreme on cohesion and flexibility might be appropriate :
 - ▶ when a family is under stress or going through a transition
- ▶ As children get older and become more acculturated to the host culture, parents may need to re-adjust family rules and expectations

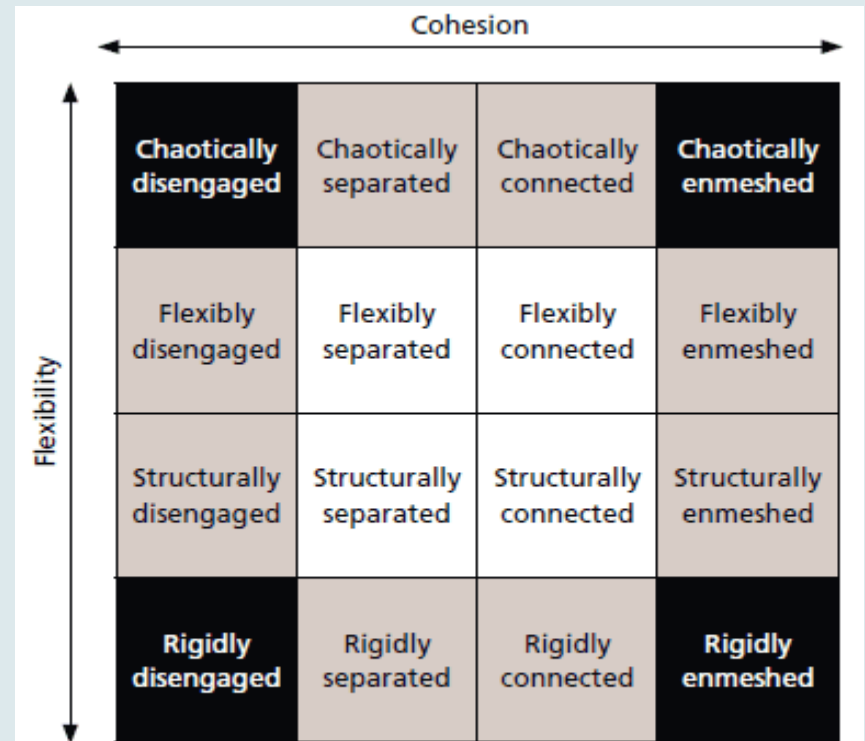


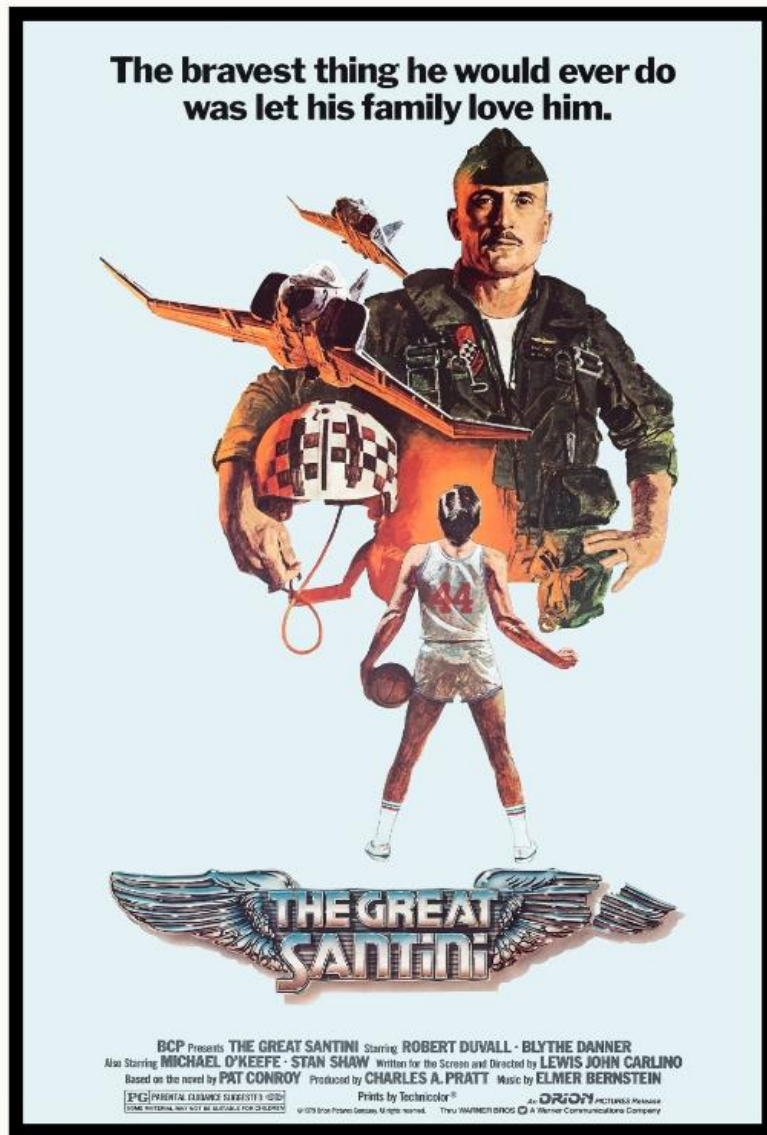
Figure 1. The Circumplex Model (after Olson, 2000)

Q4: Do couples and families maintain their levels of cohesion and flexibility throughout the family lifecycles?

- ▶ Couples/families will modify their levels of cohesion and/or flexibility to deal effectively with situational stress and developmental changes across the family life cycle



Great Santini



Scene 1

- ▶ What is the degree of closeness among family members?
- ▶ Who is in charge? How do you know?
- ▶ How do family members demonstrate loyalty?

Scene 2

- ▶ Is any negotiation allowed?
- ▶ Is respect and regard for one another demonstrated?
- ▶ Rules & roles?

Scene 3

- ▶ What happened when a rule was violated?

So, where is this family located on the circumplex map?

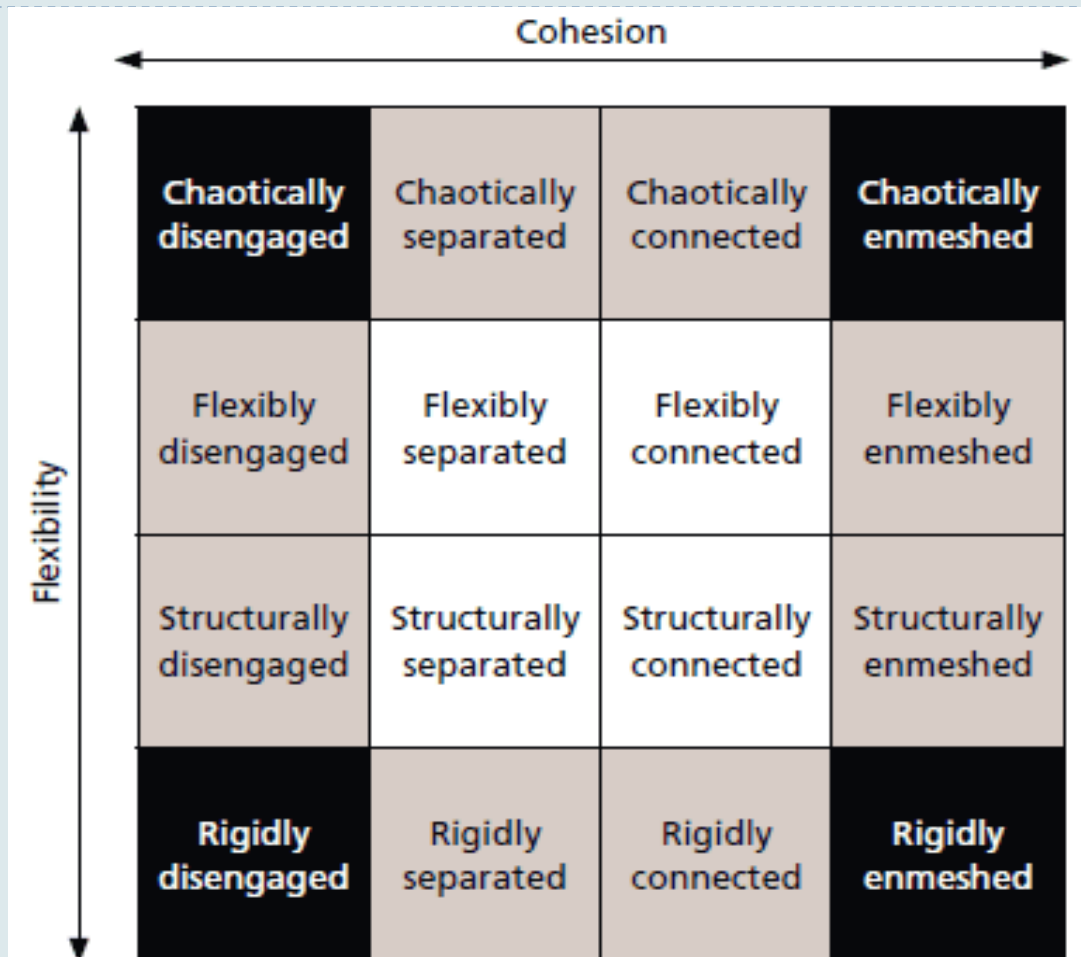


Figure 1. The Circumplex Model (after Olson, 2000)

DONALD SUTHERLAND MARY TYLER MOORE TIMOTHY HUTTON

ORDINARY PEOPLE

DIRECTED BY
ROBERT REDFORD



Ordinary People (1)

- ▶ Does this family share their feelings with one another?
- ▶ How is emotional closeness with one another in this family?
- ▶ How is physical distance maintained between family members?
- ▶ What are some implicit rules of interaction and communication in this family?



Ordinary People (2)

- ▶ Do you notice any changes in this family? In some members at least?
- ▶ Have any family member made attempts to improve relationships?
- ▶ Which family members have changed his/her communication style?
- ▶ How do you think each member of this family changed or not changed?



So, where is the Jarret family located on the circumplex map?

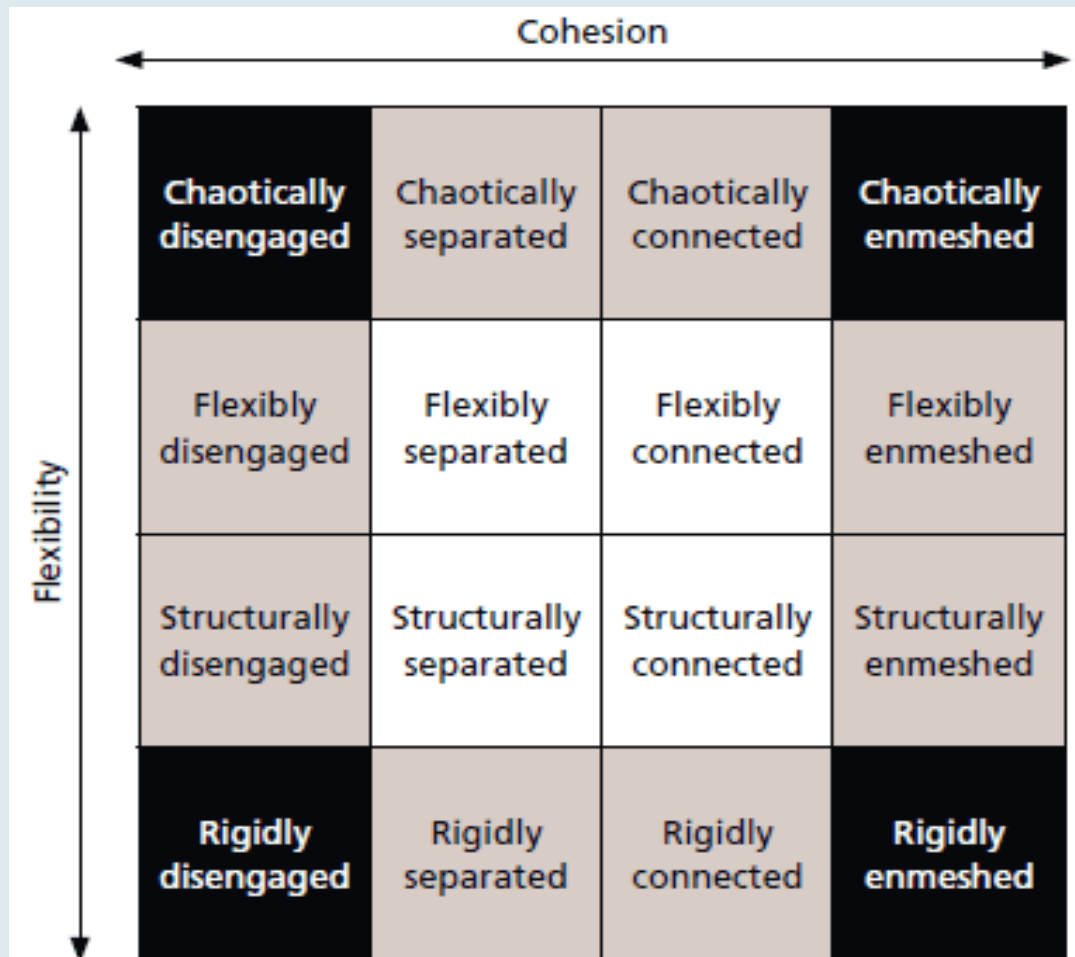


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